Into the Rainforest

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COL-310200

Manhunt

Major's Office

Lopera: Sorry, Sir, but I respectfully decline this operation.

Major Kasyan: You're already on General Carlos's deployment list, Lieutenant.

They haven't been speaking long, but the young major's throat is already drying up. He's run through this conversation a hundred times in his head.

Wearily, he straightens the stack of lists and briefings in his hand.

Major Kasyan: "... These people are working with the Apostles Brotherhood, smuggling weapons, plotting to kill Zeno soldiers and attack our outposts ..." The intel is crystal clear.

Lopera: Am I the only one around here who isn't completely loco? These "suspects" are all just ordinary people—fishers and boatmen. They've got nothing to do with the Brotherhood.

Major Kasyan: Believe me, I've spoken to General Carlos about your concerns, but he's adamant that our informant's intel is correct.

Lopera: Then Carlos has a Paraná pinecone where his brain should be. When have I been wrong? Tell me—when?

Major Kasyan: Lieutenant, watch your tone when speaking about a superior officer!

The edges of the major's mouth twitch. He suppresses a disrespectful smile and lowers his voice.

Major Kasyan: It's just like any other security operation. We snatch up a few suspects, do some interrogations, then let them go if there's nothing fishy.

Lopera: A security operation? This your first day in São Paulo or something? If Carlos sends our people into that city, then the locals will be feeding us all lead by the day's end.

Lopera: And you wait, 'cause when they fire first, there'll be "Generalissimo Carlos" screaming—"It's a riot! It's a riot!"

Major Kasyan: ...

Major Kasyan: Lieutenant, orders are orders. I don't have any leeway with our objectives, but I'll do what I can to make sure this plays out as peacefully as possible.

Major Kasyan: Besides, you shouldn't need to get your hands dirty. You have your own mission in the city: to retrieve someone named Sandro.

Lopera: What? Sandro? Who's that?

Major Kasyan: They're keeping the details on a need-to-know basis. I guess Sandro had some unpleasant run-ins with the Brotherhood. Zeno wants to find him and bring him back for his own protection—to prevent any retaliation.

Lopera: Need-to-know? Yeah, I know exactly what I need to know; I know that Carlos needs someone to do his dirty work—and I'm not doing it.

Lopera: Let some other grunt bite that bullet. I'll be in São Paulo, picking up some própolis verde.

Lopera taps the cauldron in her arms as she flutters off without any hesitation.

Major Kasyan: *sigh*

The major doesn't stop her; he knows he can't. So he returns to his operation notes, while rubbing his temples with one hand.

Hotel Room

The journey from the base to São Paulo is a well-worn path to her. As are the familiar streets that lead to her safe and hidden spot in town.

She calms her breathing as she dials and is met with a raspy, busy signal.

Lopera: ...

Hot, sticky dust rises up from São Paulo's streets and seeps through the cracks of her window blinds, mixed fragrantly with engine exhaust and the smell of old fruit.

Moldir: Hello?

Lopera: Molly!

Moldir: Pera? Why are you calling from an unsecured phone line?

Lopera: Never mind that. I need to tell you something about São Paulo before I set off.

Moldir: Before you set off? What is it? Pera, you're not causing trouble again, are you?

Lopera: That idiota Carlos is the only cause of trouble here.

Moldir: General Carlos? You've mentioned him in your reports. Father thinks ...

A vague, heavy sound from the other end interrupts the sisters' conversation.

Moldir: Hmm? Yes, it's Lopera. Understood, sir.

Lopera: Molly?

Admiral Igor: It's me.

The voice that comes next is deep yet distant and filled with restrained power, like thunder rolling over the horizon.

Lopera: Father! I was going to have Molly tell you ...

Admiral Igor: This concerns General Carlos's operation? Yes, I'm aware. The São Paulo base already submitted their plans.

Lopera: It's Carlos' paranoia on the rampage again. You can see that, can't you?

Lopera: I have to stop him, Father. If this continues, he'll have the whole city plunged into chaos.

Admiral Igor: ...

Lopera: Father ...?

The admiral's silence is unexpected. Lopera thought he would be more decisive.

In her eyes, stopping Carlos had become their highest priority.

Admiral Igor: You are on the deployment list, are you not?

Lopera: Of course, I ...

A sense of unease crawls up her spine like a spider. She knows where this conversation is headed.

Lopera: ... Yes.

Admiral Igor: Then, you are refusing your orders?

Lopera bites her lip, unable to answer.

Admiral Igor: General Carlos is your superior officer. This does not change even if he is a fool.

Admiral Igor: It's a soldier's duty to follow orders. An officer gives orders, a soldier executes them—whether it is charging a beachhead or abandoning a position.

Lopera: But, I can find out what's really happening. Father, I'll prove that his intel is wrong.

Admiral Igor: Are you a soldier, Lopera? Or a saboteur?

Admiral Igor: Lopera, if you cross that line, it could be considered treason.

Lopera: What?! No, I didn't even think of that!

Treason. The word strikes at her like a bell hammer, ringing through her skull.

Her fingers grip the edge of the table tightly, knuckles losing color.

Lopera: It can't be ...

Admiral Igor: What is the mission?

She sniffs, mustering the courage to continue.

Lopera: Sandro. I-I'm to find someone ... named Sandro.

Admiral Igor: Then find this Sandro as instructed. Complete your mission and report for duty. Do nothing else.

The name becomes a slender lifeline, a path back into his graces.

Lopera: Yes, Father. I'll find him.

Admiral Igor: I will look over your reports about the general, after you complete your mission. Moldir, is there anything else?

Muffled sounds come from the receiver as the phone is handed over.

Moldir: You know he's right, Pera.

Lopera: Hmm. Yes, I know, but how long will we keep turning a blind eye to the damage that Carlos is doing?

Moldir: Zeno is as slow to replace personnel as it is to restock supplies. There's no one available to take his post.

Moldir: But I promise I'll discuss the situation in São Paulo with Father again, when it is suitable.

There's nothing emptier than a promise awaiting suitable conditions.

Moldir: Good luck with your mission, Pera.

Dice Game

COL-310201

A Game of Dice

River Cruise

A sightseeing boat docks along a densely wooded riverbank. From the deck, it could be mistaken for the depths of the jungle. Excited tourists poke their heads out to look around.

For those seeking the appearance of adventure without venturing deep into the perilous Amazon, the outer environs of São Paulo are a fine substitute.

???: That's right, bring a few photos back home with you. I guarantee your friends back in Europe won't notice a difference.

Tourist: But when all's said and done, this ain't the Amazon—it's as fake as the crocodile bag I bought the other day.

Tourist: Can't believe I fell for it, even after he said "Ermees" secretly buys all their hides from him.

The old captain pats the tourist's polyester suit with a friendly hand, ignoring his less-than-elegant pronunciation of the name.

???: Crocodiles? My friend, if only you had come to me earlier, I would never have let you be cheated like that.

???: In fact, I know of a certain daring individual who keeps a few genuine broad-snouted caimans out in the rainforest—The kind that can crush a turtle shell with a single bite.

???: I'd be happy to make some introductions. By the way, my friend, you're carrying American dollars, aren't you?

Tourist: ...

Tourist: So what, is all this cruzeiro just completely useless?

???: Haha! Not useless at all. It's great for kindling, confetti, even waste paper for your parrot. Just take my advice, friend; exchange what you have for dollars before it sinks any lower.

???: Ah, but don't let those suits at the bank trick you. A friend of mine specializes in exchanging currencies. I guarantee you it's a better deal.

Tourist: Let me think.

He and this enthusiastic guide have been friends for a good three hours, and in that time, his host even taught him the rules to double-deck Canasta.

Somehow, this currency exchange proposal begins to seem almost credible. However, a face wreathed in bright orange interrupts the tourist's thoughts.

Lopera: Excuse me, sir. Mind if I speak with Captain Rodrygo for a moment?

Tourist: Hey, kid, you lost or something?

Rodrygo: Lopera?! I didn't know you were interested in seeing my shabby old boat.

Tourist: Are you two related?

Lopera: What makes you think I'm related to this old picareta?

Rodrygo: What a shame! You know, I've always considered you like the violently hot-headed daughter I never had, Lopera. Don't go breaking this old man's heart.

Tourist: Yeah, whatever. Just beat it, kid. Mr. Rodrygo and I have business to discuss. Why don't you go play somewhere else for a while? If you're good, maybe I'll get you some hot cocoa later.

Tourist: It's delicious—double cream, double sugar, the stuff slides down your throat like porridge—the captain was just telling me about it. You'll love it.

Lopera: Senhor, whatever Rodrygo has told you, I advise you not to believe a word of it. Including anything about his cocoa.

Rodrygo rolls his eyes, then grins.

Lopera: But why don't you try the guarana juice while you're here? It'll perk you up more than any cocoa or coffee.

Tourist: I ... did you say guarana?

Lopera: Of course. You should check further down the shore. There's bound to be a stall somewhere selling it.

True to her word, there are many stalls bunched along the shoreline, which, not far from the city, serves as a fine spot for small traders to sell their exotic goods at a good price.

Tourist: Hot dog! Well, I guess I should try something special to the area.

Tourist: See you later, Captain, and ... Miss, if I find any guarana juice, I'll be sure to bring some back for you.

Anticipating the new experience awaiting him, the tourist disembarks in a rush toward the riverbank.

Rodrygo: You do realize that you just let a big fish slip away, right? Silly little birdie.

Rodrygo shakes his head in resignation, but his tone lacks any hint of anger.

Instead, he opens his mouth into a wide and knowing smile.

Lopera: I'm tracking someone down. Find him for me, and Zeno will give you a lot more than a big fish.

Rodrygo: Zeno?

The calm, kind expression vanishes from Rodrygo's face, his brows furrowing with perceptive caution.

Lopera: I have to find Sandro.

Rodrygo: Never heard of him.

It is a lie as plain as day, said without any effort at concealment.

Lopera: Really, Rodrygo? That's what you're going with? You know you might just lose the last person in São Paulo still willing to trust you.

Lopera: If my intel is right, the last time anyone saw Sandro, he was getting off your boat.

The weathered captain remains silent, squinting, perhaps pondering, or maybe São Paulo's sun is just too bright.

Lopera: How about this?

Lopera pulls out a fancy-looking die from her waist and tosses it into an empty wooden cup on the table.

Lopera: High or low. Clear and simple.

Lopera: If I win, you tell me where Sandro is.

Rodrygo: And if I win?

Lopera slams her revolver onto the table.

Lopera: Now you know how much this gamble is worth to me.

Rodrygo offers a stiff smile. Seeing no resistance, Lopera turns the cup over to cover the die.

Lopera: You're up.

Lopera pushes the cup toward Rodrygo, indicating with a generous flair that it is his turn to roll the die.

Rodrygo sighs, extending his rough fingers over the cup—thoughtfully weighing up the pros and cons of joining in.

Rodrygo: Why did they have to send you? Carlos couldn't find some other grunt?

Lopera: You got a problem with me?

Rodrygo: The Apostles Brotherhood is looking for Sandro, too. This is anything but a simple operation.

Lopera: What? You think I can't handle a few Apostles?

The girl's hand grasps the pistol wagered in their bet, spinning it around her fingertips.

Lopera: They might as well be the bottles down at the Zeno Shooting Range. Actually, easier. Zeno's got those bottles that fly through the air.

Rodrygo: Silly little birdie, cool it! This is no place to be playing with guns.

Rodrygo: Let's do this.

Rodrygo shakes the wooden cup. Lopera places the revolver back on the table.

After a few blinks of an eye, the cup comes to a clean stop. The die spins with a crisp whirling sound within.

Rodrygo: High.

Lopera: Then I'm low.

The cup is gently lifted, revealing the die lying obediently on the table.

Lopera: Low. That's low, old man. You see? It's two.

Lopera happily returns the pistol to its holster without a hint of surprise.

Rodrygo picks up Lopera's die from the table, rubbing it in his palm.

Rodrygo: Haha! Looks like Old Rodrygo's luck is as thin as his blood these days.

Lopera: Now, the bet. Don't try to cheat me. Where is Sandro?

Rodrygo changes the subject again.

Rodrygo: I've heard Zeno is gathering troops for a move into Socorro. That true?

Lopera: Tch, Carlos es un idiota!

The momentary slip of the tongue sears through her brain like a branding iron. How could she let this low-level informant trip her up?

Rodrygo sighs, almost sympathetically.

Rodrygo: This is really bad.

Lopera: You don't understand a thing, Rodrygo. Now, I'm done with you evading my questions.

Lopera: Where is Sandro?!

The hot sun of the Southern Hemisphere burns on Rodrygo's brow. He blinks at her, weighing his options before giving in to his honor.

Rodrygo: The barata has hidden himself well. Follow me ashore, and I'll lead the way.

Lopera: I don't need a guide. Just give me a location, and you can get back to business.

Rodrygo: Sandro is hiding deep in the rainforest. You won't find anything but capybara droppings without me.

Rodrygo: Besides, I need to make sure the information I give you won't bring any harm to Sandro.

She has dealt with Rodrygo long enough to know better.

Lopera: I never knew you had such a kind heart, Rodrygo.

Rodrygo: Haha! I'm old enough that I should start going to mass every week, little birdie. Maybe this old bastard is ready to turn over a new leaf.

He tosses the die to Lopera. The cube rolls through the bright sunlight, tracing a shining arc.

The girl reaches out instinctively, tracking the arc as the small object lands square in her palm.

Lopera: I was just about to remind you to return my die.

She raises her head, looking up at Rodrygo's sunburned face. The latter is looking down to the exposed die.

Rodrygo: Another two? You have good luck with dice.

She folds her hand over the die, removing it from his scrutinizing gaze.

Lopera: Coincidence.

Rodrygo: You let me call it. How did you know I'd bet high?

Lopera: I told you it was a coincidence!

Rodrygo doesn't seem bothered by her trick.

Rodrygo: Be quicker to cover that hand next time, little birdie.

Rodrygo: I don't want to see a sweet girl like you getting roughed up over a bad bet.

Lopera: Tch, I've got a gun.

Rodrygo: There are things in this world that aren't afraid of guns, senhora. Who knows what kind of monsters are lurking out there?

Lopera: You don't really think that'll scare me, do you?

Rodrygo: We must always be prepared for the worst.

Rodrygo: Come, I'll take you to Sandro.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310202

Finding Sandro

Rainforest Riverbank

Bang—

Lopera: Did you hear that?

Rodrygo: What?

Lopera: A gunshot. But with all the reverberation from these trees, it's impossible to tell from where, or how far.

Rodrygo: Don't look at me. I'm just an ordinary human, and an old one at that. My hearing isn't so sharp.

Rodrygo: But gunshots are not uncommon here. It's always been like this, and it's only gotten worse since the Apostles Brotherhood arrived.

Rodrygo: This is what makes life on the shore so unbearable, and why I escape to the water.

Lopera: Yeah. And, how is life on the water, capitán?

The old man looks away, back to the river.

Rodrygo: Before I came to São Paulo, I knew a man. Older even than I am now.

Rodrygo: He lived beside a wide river, running a simple business. Honest his whole life, beloved by his wife and son.

Rodrygo: Then one day, he became another person, just like that, as if his mind switched with a flash of lightning.

Rodrygo: He went out and made a boat out of mimosa wood—the hard kind that never rots even in a hundred years.

Rodrygo: The day he finished it, he took that boat out and never went ashore again. The day I moved to São Paulo, he was still there, floating on the water.

Lopera: You're full of it, Rodrygo. You could at least try to make your stories sound real.

Rodrygo: Well, it's realistic enough in my eyes. To me, it's the rest of the world that feels like make-believe.

Rodrygo: Maybe he was just fed up with life and decided to leave it all behind. Maybe he didn't want to deal with the troubles of the land.

Rodrygo: I've thought of doing the same myself, but I can't quite give it all up just yet.

The man shakes his head, giving the story a strange and abrupt ending.

Rodrygo: This isn't the time to reflect on old stories. We must find Sandro soon.

Bang—

A distant, almost unreal gunshot echoes through the rainforest.

Lopera: Again?

Rodrygo: I heard it too, this time. That gun ... The caliber sounds like the same gun that Sandro carries.

Rodrygo: We should hurry. He might be in danger.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310203

A small black pellet, like a pepper kernel. Lopera holds it between her index finger and thumb, raising it up to her eye.

Rodrygo: See anything?

Lopera: Looks like a little pill. Only way we'll know what it does is if we try it.

Rodrygo: I wouldn't recommend that. I had a cat once. It died from eating something it shouldn't have.

Lopera: I'm not a cat.

She pops the little "pepper kernel" into her mouth.

Rodrygo: Wait! Don't do that! Spit that out!

Lopera: Don't worry. I've got this.

She crushes the mysterious pill between her molars. The reckless amateur alchemist's face contorts like a tourist biting into a fried ant for the first time.

Lopera: Que bizarro ... This taste, it's like little needles pricking my nose. Oh ...

Lopera: The smell is all up in my nose. I can't seem to swallow it.

Lopera: And I feel a little ... dizzy ...

Rodrygo: ...?

Lopera: Rodrygo, why do you look so different?

Rodrygo: ...? ...!!!

...

Lopera: ...?

Lopera: Where am I?

Father: You can't go out, Lopera.

Lopera: ...?!

Lopera: Papa?

Lopera: Why would I go out? Oh, right, I was going to the carnival.

Lopera: Please, I'm only going to the carnival!

Father: It's not safe outside.

Lopera: But Nydia and Laura have already been to the carnival, and they said it was safe.

Father: They didn't invite you, did they?

Lopera: I-I don't know why! I wanted to join them there to see if we can clear up whatever's bugging them.

Lopera: Nothing bad is going to happen there, Papa. There are police there, and I'm old enough to go now. Please, we could go together.

Father: I said you can't go, Lopera! You are not to go to that carnival!

Lopera: Never? Why?!

Father: Don't question me on this. You are my daughter. You will obey.

Father: Isn't this manor large enough for you to wreak havoc in?!

Lopera: There's nothing to do here! I want to go out.

Lopera: What are you doing?

Lopera: No! Please, don't lock me in!

Lopera: No!!

...

...

Rodrygo: Lopera, listen to me! Stop!

Lopera: —!

The two of them wrestle on the riverbank, but one has a clear advantage in strength.

Lopera: What's going on?

Rodrygo: Thank God! You almost killed me, little birdie. That's what's going on. Luckily, you snapped out of it.

Rodrygo: You need to stop eating just any old thing that pops out of that cauldron.

Rodrygo: Come. I'll take you to Sandro. Now have some water first.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310204

Long journeys necessitate a little small talk to ease the nerves, and the older the travelers, it seems, the more likely the topic turns to family.

Rodrygo: Kid, you never talk about your parents. You're not Brazilian, so what are you?

Lopera: No. I'm originally from Colombia.

Rodrygo: Bananas, coffee, and a military junta—not so different, really.

Rodrygo: At least you won't get homesick.

She has no desire to engage with the old man's banter. In her heart, she feels far more nostalgia for the dry, yellow steppes of Kazakhstan than for the country of her birth.

Admiral Igor and his children did not have a fixed home.

Lopera: Zeno is my home. As for Colombia, Brazil, it doesn't matter.

Rodrygo stops his pace and turns around to inquire further.

Rodrygo: How can Zeno be your home? It's just an army.

Rodrygo: I once served in the army, too. Really, it's no different from any other job. People from all over bunched together, just trying to survive.

Rodrygo: Many years ago, someone told me, "Join the army. You'll make friends for life, and no one in Rio will dare look down on you again."

Rodrygo: But life after retirement was not so good, and all of those "friends for life" dried up in the end.

Rodrygo: Then I heard someone say, "Go to São Paulo. The soda factory there pays in dollars. Your children will suffer no more."

Rodrygo: Not long after I arrived, the factory closed down. I didn't even get my last month's wages. Worse, I found out my coworkers had taken it.

Rodrygo claps his big hands together, as if creating a dramatic pause.

Rodrygo: At the end of all that, I finally understood. Family is the only thing that matters. No one else will ever truly care about you in this world.

Rodrygo: Once the war is over, once the factory closes, when you leave with empty hands and nothing more than you came with, and you worry every day about what your children will eat.

Lopera: Wait, you have children?

Rodrygo sweeps his large hand lightly over Lopera's head.

Rodrygo: Of course. A daughter, she was about your age.

Rodrygo: But she never made it out of Rio. She died.

Lopera: Sorry.

The man puts on a smile.

Rodrygo: It was my fault. I shouldn't have joined the army, then the cartel wouldn't have gone after her to get to me.

Rodrygo: But I know that she must be in heaven because she used all her persuasion to get God to send me my little boat. See, she has blessed me already.

Rodrygo: Maybe that's why I want to live on it like that old man, just waiting for the day that my own mind will let me flick that switch.

Rodrygo: But now is not that day. I still need to help you find this Sandro, don't I?

Lopera: Right. We need to find Sandro fast.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310205

Perilous Rainforest

Jungle Village

Two heads, one big and one small, peek out from behind the damp, rotting planks.

First the big, dark one, then the small, red one.

Lopera: Is this the place?

Rodrygo: Of course. Sure as shooting.

Lopera: Rodrygo, I think you must've taken a wrong turn somewhere. There's no one here.

Rodrygo: Even if Sandro isn't here, it shouldn't be abandoned. There were people living here.

Rodrygo: But remember the gunshots earlier? Perhaps the Apostles Brotherhood got here before us.

Lopera: Well, since there's no one, we don't exactly need to stick to the shadows.

Lopera: Come on, let's take a look around and see what we can find.

The girl pokes her small frame out from behind the planks before Rodrygo pulls her back.

Lopera: What?!

Rodrygo: Wait a minute.

Rodrygo: Look closely. Something's moving behind the clothes on that laundry line.

Lopera: Hmmm.

Lopera squints as though aiming at an enemy, then widens her eyes in surprise. There is indeed someone behind the hanging, wrinkled clothes.

Wearing Zeno colors.

Lopera: Oh, see the colors? They're friendly. No need to worry.

Rodrygo: No. Things don't seem right, little birdie. That soldier looks strange to me. Trust this unlucky old thing's intuition on this.

Lopera: What the hell are you talking about?

The girl doesn't intend to listen to him. She gets up and slips out of cover again.

But Rodrygo is quick to pull her back once more.

Rodrygo: Wait, don't do that! You trying to get yourself shot?

Lopera attempts to call the Zeno soldier over, but an oily hand, reeking of fish, covers her mouth entirely.

Lopera: Hmph! Let go, damn it!

Rodrygo's strong grip renders her struggle futile. The two wait in an awkward, tense stance for the Zeno soldier's next move.

Zeno Corporal: ...?

The soldier does not seem to have taken any notice of their hidden struggle, but he moves cautiously still.

Rodrygo's attempt to prove his judgment correct loses out to Lopera's struggling impatience.

Bang—

Rodrygo: *cough*

Rodrygo: Damn it! What just happened?

A freshly made smoke bomb releases a cloud of moth-scale dust, giving the girl a chance to break free from his clutches.

Lopera: Hey! Have you lost your mind, Rodrygo?!

Rodrygo: *cough* Don't go ...

The alchemical explosion startles the soldier, who turns his gun toward the smoke.

Zeno Corporal: ...?

Zeno Corporal: Who's there?

The girl emerging from the pale smoke is unmistakable. Anyone who serves at the São Paulo base would recognize her in an instant.

Zeno Corporal: It's ... you?!

Lopera: Hey, it's me, Lopera. Put the gun down.

Lopera: Come on, I need your help. Some old fool has been threatening me.

The corporal's frame stiffens, unmoving except for his eyes, which twitch wildly.

Zeno Corporal: Antonio, someone's here!

Another nervous Zeno soldier emerges from a nearby house, rifle in hand.

Lopera: What are you two doing? You recognize me, don't you? Seriously, you guys are so—

The Zeno corporal doesn't answer, but her training and instincts read the twitching movements and telegraph his intention—he's preparing to fire.

Lopera: ...?!

Rodrygo: Have a fish!

Zeno Corporal: ...?!

A fermented fish flies through the air, momentarily distracting the aggressors.

Zeno Corporal: Fire!

Lopera is pushed through a narrow door, a spray of bullets zipping over her head.

Lopera: What are they doing?!

Rodrygo: You gotta fight back, kid! Where's that gun of yours?!

[English text unavailable]

COL-310206

Antonio is the first to fall, toppling over into a heap, his soul seeping out with the blood pooling at his side.

But the other soldier remains wounded, alive.

Zeno Corporal: N-No!

Lopera: Traitor!

The small but powerful tip of a shoe kicks the soldier in the shoulder, digging into a fresh bullet wound.

Zeno Corporal: Ahhhh!

The corporal curls his body over to the other side, only to be flipped back over by Rodrygo.

Rodrygo: Enough, that's twelve kicks already. One more, and you might put him down for good.

Rodrygo: We still have questions for him.

Lopera: What's going on? Tell me everything, right from the beginning.

Zeno Corporal: I ... well, first ... after I joined Zeno—

Rodrygo: Meu Deus, not the whole damn story. How about this for a start—why are you here?

Zeno Corporal: I-I was just out gathering supplies.

Rodrygo sighs heavily, as though he has already guessed the whole truth.

Rodrygo: And who were you gathering supplies for?

The corporal averts his eyes, hoping silence might save him.

Lopera: Oh? That's how you want to play it, huh?

Lopera pulls out her revolver and presses it to the corporal's temple, the cold barrel breaking his will in an instant.

Zeno Corporal: No, no, no. I'll tell you everything.

He knows well enough—this little birdie wouldn't hesitate to execute him. Antonio's body is proof.

Lopera: Spit it out.

Zeno Corporal: I don't know who gave the order. I only know he's from the ... Apostles Brotherhood.

Zeno Corporal: They wanted food, sugar, rum, even people—everything!

Lopera: The Brotherhood?!

Lopera leaves a purple bruise on his cheekbone with the butt of her gun.

Zeno Corporal: Ah! You lunatic!

Lopera: How did you get mixed up with those bastards?

Zeno Corporal: Haven't you felt how things at Zeno have changed? You didn't notice anything?

Zeno Corporal: Of course ... You're not like us. You're not ordinary. But we are. We only joined Zeno to make a living, not to serve that lunatic Carlos.

Zeno Corporal: This is all his fault. We can't let him bring another massacre to Socorro. The Brotherhood said they would help us.

Lopera: Be more specific—what is going on with Carlos?

A momentary spasm of contempt flashes across the corporal's lips.

Zeno Corporal: Carlos is dead.

Lopera: What? He's dead?!

Lopera: That can't be. He was alive when I left the base!

Zeno Corporal: Then you just missed it. I bet the maggots are already feasting on him by now.

The corporal shivers from blood loss and the cold. The same chill slowly creeps up Lopera's spine.

Lopera: This doesn't make any sense.

Rodrygo exhales a murky cloud of hot breath to one side, unnoticed by Lopera.

Rodrygo: Carlos ...

Rodrygo: If what he said is true ... Oh, God. This could turn São Paulo upside down. Who'd have thought Zeno would end up in a mess like this?

Rodrygo: And Sandro ...

His coarse fingers rub the corners of his eyes.

Rodrygo: ...

Rodrygo: Seems like it, don't it?

Rodrygo returns to Lopera's side and places his hand gently on her arm, lowering the barrel of the gun.

Rodrygo: No, you know the score, little birdie. They killed Carlos, then joined up with the Apostles Brotherhood.

Rodrygo: In military terms, it sounds like mutiny.

Lopera shakes off Rodrygo's hand and presses the gun hard into the corporal's forehead, the cold metal sinking into his skin.

Zeno Corporal: Aaah!

The soldier grabs for the gun, but his blood-drained strength fails him. In his weakened state, he is no match for Lopera.

He fails to move the barrel even half an inch.

Zeno Corporal: Are you going to kill me?

Lopera: You're already an enemy in Zeno's eyes.

Judgment has been handed down.

Zeno Corporal: No! I'm not! I-I just wanted a way out. Please! Ask me anything, I'll tell you!

Rodrygo takes over the interrogation.

Rodrygo: Where is Sandro?

Zeno Corporal: Of course, yeah ... Wait, Sandro? Who is Sandro? You came to this village to find him?

The condemned man's expression is sincere, and on the verge of death he has no reason—nor likely the ability—to lie.

Zeno Corporal: There's no one else here. No one's been here. We just ran away after what happened to Carlos.

Lopera: But you killed your comrades to escape the base, right?

Zeno Corporal: I ...

Lopera: Darn it!

Zeno Corporal: Ugh!

Lopera: Traitor!

Zeno Corporal: *cough*

Rodrygo: Lopera!

Rodrygo pulls her away before she can cause any more harm to the dying corporal.

Zeno Corporal: Please ... whatever you want ... just leave me here ...

He musters the courage to look Lopera in the eye one last time, his eyes swimming in a cocktail of fluids—blood, sweat, and tears.

Zeno Corporal: We ... were comrades once, right?

Zeno Corporal: I remember ... uh, playing cards with you. You were cheating, but I didn't care ...

Zeno Corporal: ... For the sake of those old games ... you remember my name, do you ...?

The corporal throws his hand across his chest, grabbing at the pocket on his uniform.

Lopera: Don't move a muscle.

Zeno Corporal: It's not a weapon ... I just want to ... show you ...

The corporal continues to fumble at his chest, and Lopera raises her firearm. Both of their arms tremble.

In this moment, the three of them freeze in silent agreement, only a trembling hand moves, reaching into an open pocket.

A gust of wind gathers the stench of the rainforest's decay, blowing humid, sticky air across the scene.

Lopera: ...

The thick forest isolates their little unfolding drama from the rest of the world. There is no one else here but them and a fragile, dying man, who hopes he can tell her his name.

Zeno Corporal: Lucas ...

The air is so thick it feels toxic. In the moment, it feels like all of this is just some sick hallucination.

Only a nightmare, a fleeting moment with no consequences. She doesn't have to pull this trigger.

She could leave now, return to the base, as though nothing happened. That idiot Carlos might even still be alive, but at the very least things will be back in order.

Lopera: Lucas ...

The dark gun barrel forms a black sun in the Zeno corporal's eyes.

And then the sun explodes.

Lopera: You have to learn the consequences of your actions.

Disloyalty and betrayal can never be forgiven.

Rodrygo: ...

Rodrygo squats down, first taking the corporal's pistol, then reaching into his chest pocket.

Rodrygo: It's a dog tag. Should we take it with us?

Without a single word, Lopera grabs the dog tag and tosses it into her cauldron.

She sits on the ground. Never before has a battle left her so exhausted, physically and mentally. Her thoughts are as tangled as her ginger hair.

Lopera: Sandro isn't here.

Her words sound like a whimper.

Lopera: I want to go back.

Rodrygo: Go back? No, you can't go back. Not yet. We've still got a ways to go.

Rodrygo: Come. I'll take you to Sandro. We have to keep looking for him.

The girl jumps back up to her feet indignantly.

Lopera: What did you say?

Rodrygo: Lopera, listen to me.

Lopera: Why should I listen to you? Last I checked, you weren't in my chain of command!

Rodrygo: Maybe not, but it weren't for me, kid, you would have walked right up to those traitors and probably caught a bullet like your general.

Lopera: ...!

His point was, unfortunately, irrefutable. She could only offer a huff in reply.

Rodrygo: We have no idea what the situation is now! Is your Zeno base now a rebel stronghold, or are there loyal soldiers still holding on there? And what is the Apostles Brotherhood doing through all of this?

Rodrygo: Perhaps Lucas and Antonio knew more, but the dead don't speak to likes of us.

Lopera: I ...

Rodrygo: I'm not blaming you.

Rodrygo: I only mean the jungle may be the safest place for us now. So, let's get Sandro first. At least then we'll have another ally.

Lopera's mind is swirling, still too chaotic to form her own plan. Rodrygo seems to offer the only path forward.

She nods.

Lopera: Fine, we keep going.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310207

Carnival Fireworks

After another harrowing battle, Lopera proves once again the capabilities of a loyal, first-class Zeno soldier.

Lopera: Sandro ... isn't here either.

She paces back and forth across the creaky wooden walkways, idly picking up small items to throw into her cauldron.

Rodrygo returns after around ten minutes. Lopera sees him emerge from a corner, his face beaming.

Rodrygo: Look what I found!

Rodrygo grins, holding out a metal box dotted with colorful buttons and dials.

Lopera: A radio? Is it working?

Rodrygo: Luck is best saved for times like this.

Rodrygo: A shortwave signal like this should be able to reach anywhere in the whole world.

He places the odd-looking portable radio in front of Lopera, who is still staring at it with disbelief.

Rodrygo: I knew it was here. I've been to this village before. I sold them this radio in exchange for some redwood and caiman hides.

Rodrygo: Oh, and some jaboticabas—those things that look like the eyes of the dead.

Lopera examines the unusual machine. It's far from Zeno standard-issue, but with a little time, she's able to figure it out. Save for one question.

Lopera: What's the power source?

Rodrygo smiles and places a small crank between his legs.

Lopera: That's done it.

Rodrygo: It's a crank-powered radio. Works in any conditions. The only downside is, this old goat has to add a little elbow grease.

Lopera: We don't know the situation at the Zeno base. It's possible contacting them would just put a target on our backs.

Lopera: I need to contact Admiral Igor.

Rodrygo: Do as you think best, little birdie. Old Rodrygo will just keep cranking.

Lopera turns the dial, modulating the frequency at a specific point.

Lopera: Long, short, short, long. Hmm, then two longs together.

Lopera: It should be something like that.

After sending her identification code, Lopera waits, listening to the buzzing static and the drone of the crank.

Admiral Igor: Lopera?

Lopera: Father!

She second-guesses herself. The voice seems so clear in the moment. In the static, nothing else comes through.

Lopera: I can hear your voice. Can you hear me? Father?

Lopera: Hey!

Lopera: Rodrygo, what's going on?!

Rodrygo: I have no idea!

Rodrygo: All I can do is keep cranking. Crank, crank, crank.

Lopera: Father?! Can you hear me?

Lopera: Crank harder, Rodrygo!

Rodrygo: I'm working harder than a dog, girl!

Admiral Igor: ... sit ... uation ...?

There's no time to worry about the signal strength. Lopera divulges everything that has happened so far as clearly as she can.

Lopera: Zeno troops stationed in São Paulo have mutinied. General Carlos is presumed dead, and the rebels have joined with the Apostles Brotherhood.

The old radio struggles as it bridges continents, and like a fragile spider's web, seems unable to bear more than a few words at a time.

Admiral Igor: Zeno ... you ...

Lopera: Me? I remain on mission, looking for Sandro. Can you read me?

Admiral Igor: ... Sandro ... find ...

Admiral Igor: Be careful ...

Lopera: Find Sandro? Be careful of what?

Static drowns out the line again.

Lopera: Darn it! Damn this thing! Piece of s**t!

Bang!

Her attempt at concussive repair does more harm than good. The radio sputters out, and the line goes dead.

Rodrygo: Wait. Don't do that. You realize we can't get this thing fixed out here, don't you?

Lopera: Damn thing was useless anyway.

Lopera hangs up the receiver and turns away in a breathless huff. Their only means of communication is completely dead.

Rodrygo: Must be the humidity. The circuits are rusted to hell.

Rodrygo drops the generator, and approaches Lopera patting her on her hunched shoulders.

Rodrygo: Its work here is done.

Lopera reloads the spent chambers of her revolver as she moves toward the edge of the village.

Lopera: Mine isn't ...

Lopera: Come on. Let's go find Sandro.

Bang—

Another warning shot rings out, and a flock of colorful birds screech and squawk as they soar up above the canopy.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310208

Jungle Swamp

Bang—

The unbroken flurry of gunshots echoes both near and far, producing a mirage-like sensation in the depths of the rainforest.

Bang, bang!

Lopera strains her eyes, scanning for any sign of the shooters through the dense foliage.

Lopera: Darn it! Can't we fire off a couple of shots to let him know it's us?

Rodrygo: No go, little birdie. Sandro is a scrawny little thing, and as timid as he is tiny.

Rodrygo: Kid, calm down. He's quick on his feet—very quick indeed. Only thing we can do is move faster.

Lopera: Maybe we'd make more progress in a boat?

Rodrygo: No, one wrong turn, and you'll lose any chance of finding him.

Lopera: Tch. Then try this.

Lopera pops a few cocoa-powdered candies into her mouth and tosses a few to Rodrygo.

Rodrygo: Wait, don't do that! I thought I told you not to eat any old thing that popped out of your cauldron!

Lopera: Stop worrying. I'm confident about these ones. They should give you an energy boost.

He watches Lopera for a little while, and seeing no adverse effects, Rodrygo hesitantly swallows the energizing candy—his stamina was starting to wane.

Rodrygo: Oh, this is really ...

Lopera: How is it? Feeling a little lighter?

The man's eyes soften unconsciously, taking on a glazed quality as he looks back at her.

Rodrygo: Of course, but ...

Rodrygo: Nita ...?

Lopera: What? Who's Nita?

Rodrygo's pupils dilate. Lopera notices for the first time that he has light-colored eyes.

His hand weakly clenches and releases, and he suddenly quickens his pace, leaving Lopera several steps behind.

Lopera: Heh!

Rodrygo: Why now, of all times, do you enter my mind?

Rodrygo: No, my heart will always be open to you, my Nita. It's just that I'm used to seeing you only in dreams.

Rodrygo: Nita. Please, I'm doing something very important now.

Lopera: Stop running, Rodrygo!

Rodrygo: Yes, I will save him. I promise you.

Lopera: What are you doing?!

The aging man bounds over wet roots and mud with catlike ease, moving faster than Lopera, who finds herself bogged down and tripped.

Bang! A gunshot pierces through the air.

Rodrygo: Hm?

The gunshot seems close enough to be a warning. Rodrygo's pace slows.

The girl closes the gap between them, getting near enough to hear Rodrygo's breathless muttering.

Rodrygo: No, no, don't be afraid, Nita.

Lopera: Wait! Rodrygo, I think I've figured it out! You're not used to the side effects of these things; they can make you a little ...

Lopera decides on a method to speed Rodrygo's recovery, scooping up a handful of water from a muddy puddle.

Bang—

Rodrygo: No, that couldn't be a gunshot. Of course, it wasn't. This place is very safe, my little birdie.

Lopera: ...?

The girl freezes. The muddy water she was about to splash him with seeps out through her fingers.

Rodrygo: Of course. They're only celebrating the carnival outside. There's no need to be afraid.

Lopera: Rodrygo?

Rodrygo: Hmm, yes, I'll go get you a gift from the carnival, but you have to promise me one thing.

Rodrygo: Never leave this room, ever, or I'll have to lock you in.

Rodrygo: You can't go to the carnival. No, you must not leave, not tonight.

The remaining mud splashes down onto her foot.

Lopera: Rodrygo.

Rodrygo: Hmmm.

His eyes have grown increasingly cloudy, until they become like two indistinguishable pools of gray water, and then just as quickly the clouds recede.

Rodrygo: Epa, you fell over a bit back there, didn't you? Your hands are all covered in mud.

Lopera: It's nothing. Welcome back to reality.

Lopera walks ahead of Rodrygo, leaving him staring at her blankly as if in a trance.

Lopera: Come on now. We're not catching up to him in this mud.

Mapinguari

COL-310209

Mapinguari

The shallow water ahead seems infested with mosquitoes of outrageous proportions. They hover across the surface, producing an audible buzz.

Rodrygo: This is it. Captain Rodrygo's very own private lake.

Lopera: What's so special about this place, pernilongos and piranhas aside?

Rodrygo: See that boat over there? That's the very one I got after I was fired from the soda factory.

Rodrygo: Something came over me. I wanted to be like that old man on the water, to live on that boat. But, as you can see, I couldn't handle that kind of freedom.

Rodrygo: But, more importantly, I have a cabin nearby, with a few goodies for us both.

Rodrygo: Including some submachine guns and a few bulletproof vests. Not cheap trash either, American-made. They might be a bit damp, but they should still be functional.

Lopera: How'd you get your hands on those?

A bitter ripple spreads across Rodrygo's face.

Rodrygo: Kid, that cabin holds Old Rodrygo's biggest secrets. Some things are best left unknown, little birdie.

Rodrygo: Eh, how many bullets do you have left? Mind sharing a few?

Lopera: Not many. Didn't you pick up any from those rebels?

Rodrygo: Yes, but I've injured my hand, so I'm not too steady with a gun. I'll need a few more to account for my shoddy aim—Just for now, they'll be plenty in the cabin.

Lopera: Tch, fine.

Lopera reluctantly grabs a fistful of bullets and shoves them into Rodrygo's hand, not a small number either, at least two-thirds of what she had left.

Lopera: I'm not that bad a shot.

Rodrygo: This should be enough for me.

Rodrygo: Come on, let's walk around the lake. Stay low—who knows if we might run into more rebels.

Lopera: Hmm. Lead the way.

Rodrygo hunches forward, parting the dense underbrush layer by layer. Lopera follows behind in military fashion, scanning for trouble.

A pair of eyes skilled at distinguishing insect and fruit species carefully scrutinizes each leaf for hidden threats.

Lopera: Here. No, just a bird.

Lopera: Oh. Heh heh, an armadillo. You don't see those every day.

Despite her casual tone, she maintains a firm grip on her weapon.

Bang—

This time, it is Rodrygo who fires first.

Lopera: Where are they?!

Rodrygo: Fire, to the brush!

Lopera raises her gun, aiming at the waving leaves.

A shot rings out, quickly followed by another in quick succession.

Rodrygo: Keep going, kid. Aim right where I fired!

The hammer clicks empty. Lopera steadily draws a captured pistol, continuing her barrage, magazine after magazine, until it too is spent.

Lopera: I'm out of bullets!

Rodrygo keeps firing, the roars of his rifle drowning out Lopera's voice.

At last, Rodrygo stops pulling the trigger.

Rodrygo: Not even a mapinguari could survive that.

Lopera: Let's hope we killed a mapinguari then. I'll check it out.

Rodrygo: No. There's no time. Let's make our way to the cabin first. We need to stock up in case there's more.

Lopera: But—

Rodrygo: We're close, come on!

Rodrygo sprints off, seemingly uncaring of any would-be enemies spotting him.

Lopera: Hey! You ...

Lopera taps her empty cylinder and chases after him impatiently.

Rodrygo's Cabin

The cabin's interior looks as though the owner left in a hurry and never returned. Not at all like the kind of place one would hide valuable weapons and equipment.

Rodrygo combs over the room, producing nothing but clouds of dust.

Rodrygo: *cough* I should've come back once in a while to tidy up.

Rodrygo: This cabinet ...

Crash! Rodrygo pulls out a long oil-cloth bag from the clutter, then just as quickly crumples it and stuffs it back.

Rodrygo: Haha. This, oh boy, this is no good. Just an old relic from the boat. Haha, I was going to use it to store my Cordell novels.

Lopera: Give it up, Rodrygo. You've been searching for close to half an hour.

Lopera stands by the window, keeping her eyes on the outside, ready for any potential threat.

Rodrygo: Nothing.

Rodrygo's gaze flickers, briefly landing on Lopera before turning back to the clutter.

Rodrygo: Kid. This is bad.

Lopera: Look at what your mapinguari did. Now we're out of ammo.

The girl pauses for a long time. Her words come out like a hard bone rising from her stomach, catching in her throat.

Lopera: We've lost Sandro for certain.

Rodrygo: We've been walking through the rainforest for so long that the mosquitoes eating away at us have changed shifts. It'll be a miracle if we don't catch a fever three days from now.

Rodrygo: If you were to give up, I don't think even the great Admiral Igor would blame you.

Lopera: You're wrong. Who said anything about giving up? I'll find this rat, even if it's just his corpse.

Rodrygo: How could Sandro be dead?

Rodrygo sighs with contempt. He turns again, his shadowed face now dark and indistinct.

Rodrygo: You can't take him to Zeno. I'll take him across the border.

Rodrygo's words are emotionless, as if stating an agreed-upon fact.

Lopera: Wait, you mean you'll leave Brazil??

Lopera: Let's get this straight—after you help me find Sandro, I'm taking him back to Zeno. He has no choice in the matter. Whatever happens after that is none of your business.

Rodrygo: But ... It wasn't supposed to be like this. This was supposed to go down easy. Now, with Carlos dead ...

Rodrygo punches the cabinet, leaving a shallow dent.

Rodrygo: You know that Zeno is tearing itself apart from within? Who will keep their promises? Who can I trust with Sandro's safety?

Lopera: This little mutiny won't last long. Admiral Igor will put things right. We'll handle all of these traitors.

Rodrygo: I can't put my faith in a stranger a thousand miles away.

Lopera: He's my father. I know what kind of man he is.

Lopera: Admiral Igor knows what's best. He will make the right decision. He always does. Sandro will be safest under his protection.

Rodrygo: The "right decision"? You really think there is such a thing?

Rodrygo shrugs, hanging his face.

Rodrygo: I've never trusted anyone with a chest full of medals. Those little things start to blind their eyes.

Lopera suddenly steps up to Rodrygo, hand on her gun, looking up into his shadowed eyes.

Lopera: Idiota! You don't know anything about him! Every medal Admiral Igor wears is a mark of honor. Don't speak about my father that way!

Rodrygo: Kid, it's not whether those honors are real that matters.

Rodrygo: He adopted you, right? How long have you known him?

Rodrygo: Not fifteen years? Is it ten? Less than five?

Lopera: ...

The girl's silence gives Rodrygo his answer.

Rodrygo: Just a few short years—what sort of father is that? Have you ever seen the world through his eyes? That world he built with the power he wields?

Lopera: I—

Rodrygo: You haven't, kid, or you wouldn't know Old Rodrygo, and the reek of fish and sweat.

Rodrygo: If Igor had ever lifted you above his head, people like me would be nothing but ants to you.

Rodrygo: Cling on to his boots all you want, but his shoulders are too high. He won't pull you up there. He never will.

Rodrygo: Kid, maybe you should think about your real father? Then you'll understand what I mean.

Lopera: Understand what? He's a malparido, an evil man! That's the only thing I need to understand.

Rodrygo remains still, like a dark wall, waiting for the speaker to tell her story.

Lopera: He betrayed everyone who trusted him. He sold them all out to a goddamn fruit company. Handed over their plans, their leaders, like a good little lapdog.

Lopera: They could've done it. Just one more push, and those bastards would've been pushed out of Colombia, bananas and all.

Lopera: But, then, it all fell apart. The shooting echoed through the streets from morning until dark.

Lopera: You know? He told me they were "victory fireworks" for the strikers!

Lopera: Sound familiar, Rodrygo?

The man doesn't answer. He faces the wall, unspeaking.

Rodrygo: Then I suppose at least your father never had to work on the plantation again.

Lopera: Never. He dressed like some kind of big boss, sweating through his suit every day but still refusing to take it off.

Lopera: But we could never go home. We were always on the run after that, sleeping with one eye open, always afraid.

Lopera: I never understood why people looked at me like I was some pest, why they threw their muddy chanclas at us.

Lopera: He moved us far from the city, always in isolated places.

Rodrygo: How did you find out about all this?

The girl's gaze drops to her empty revolver.

Lopera: Nydia told me. You don't need to know who she is.

Lopera: I still don't know how she found me after all those years and so far away.

Lopera: Until that night, when she knocked on my window.

Lopera: I opened it for her, but she didn't come in. I thought I was seeing a ghost.

Lopera: Nydia was a mestizo, with skin as dark as cocoa, but that night her face was pale as the moon. Her skinny arms were clinging to my windowsill.

Lopera: She said to me in a hoarse voice.

Nydia: Lopera, I figured it out. It was your father who betrayed us all.

Lopera: My father ... What are you talking about?!

Nydia: They're dead, Lopera. My family, my father, mother, brother and sister—dead.

Lopera: But the strike ... Isn't it successful?

Nydia: No. They knew about it. They shot everyone, chased them through the streets, then buried them like garbage.

Nydia: I saw it. There's yellow-leafed banana trees growing over the pit.

Father: Stop! Thief!

Lopera: —!

Nydia: I'm sick, Lopera. Dying, I think.

Lopera: Don't say that! Come inside!

Nydia: Never. I won't. Not into his house.

Lopera: Just grab my hand! Come on, Nydia!

Father: There! On the windowsill! Get her!

Nydia: I don't hate you, Lopera. I just wanted you to know—

Father: Where's my gun?

Lopera: No!

Lopera: ...

Lopera steps back three paces from Rodrygo.

She doesn't need to say more. A dryness chokes her through the last words.

Rodrygo: Do you ever want to see your hometown again?

Lopera: It's gone, Rodrygo. What happened there ... you can't go back to that. Maybe you don't understand.

Lopera: Zeno is my home. That's enough for me.

Rodrygo: Zeno? Hasn't all that's happened today shown you Zeno's true colors?

Lopera: ...

The girl remains silent, letting Rodrygo's words fall to the ground.

Rodrygo: You still think you're the heroes, don't you? There are no heroes in this world, kid—you either live on the water or fight on the shore.

Rodrygo: On the water, there's peace. Maddening peace and loneliness, like the old man and his mimosa wood boat.

Rodrygo: But as soon as you step on the shore, you're at war. To survive, we must become something shameful.

Rodrygo is silent for a moment; his thumb rubs over his knife's handle.

Rodrygo: There's no place left for heroes.

Rodrygo: I wish I could live on the water; I do. But there are those on land I still must care for.

Lopera: But, you said your family was all gone.

Rodrygo's smile is like a crack in hard leather.

Rodrygo: Don't you want poor Sandro to escape the chaos of São Paulo?

Lopera: No way! Why would I care about that!

For the first time, Lopera scrutinizes the man before her, wondering if he was bitten by a poisonous snake in the forest.

Lopera: I don't understand.

Lopera: Something's been off from the start of this? Why have you been following me all this way?

Lopera: Who is Sandro to you?

Confusion and rage erupt from her throat.

Lopera: And what's your business here anyway?!

Rodrygo's dark face is like an iron plate, beaten a hundred times.

Lopera: Enough! I'm done with you. I can find him myself.

Rodrygo: Sandro will never go with you!

The man roars back.

Lopera: Why do you care about some nobody?!

Rodrygo: What is he to you? Just another goddamn medal from your father, right?!

Rodrygo: When your Admiral Igor shows up, my poor Sandro will be paraded around like some trophy! And you, you'll just use him as a cover to hide the mess you've made.

Rodrygo: I can't trust your admiral to protect him, and, now I fear, little birdie, that I can't trust you either.

Lopera: You've lost your mind, old man.

Rodrygo walks away from the wall and heads for the door.

Lopera: Don't move. You need to explain yourself before we leave.

Rodrygo: No. You're not going anywhere, Lieutenant.

Rodrygo raises his gun, determined to entrust Lopera's fate to his trembling hand.

Lopera: You!

He fires, but the bullet hits nothing but shadows.

Lopera reflexively raises her gun to return fire, but there is nothing in the chamber to meet the cocked hammer.

Lopera: Damn! You tricked me into wasting my ammo, didn't you?!

Rodrygo: Kid, I hate to kill you. So, let's just play another game. This time we'll really let fate decide.

Lopera is pinned down by the dark muzzle of his rifle as he retreats out the door. He slams it closed and begins locking it from the outside.

The girl rushes to the door—as a blind bullet pierces through, severing a few strands of her orange hair.

Rodrygo: Don't use up all your luck just yet, kid!

Rodrygo's voice rattles through the door, along with the clinking of rusted chains.

Lopera: Hah. You think this cage can stop me?!

Rodrygo: These locks won't hold you long, little birdie. I know you'll escape.

Rodrygo: But I'll have Sandro safely away from here long before you do.

Rodrygo: It wasn't supposed to be like this, kid. Why didn't Carlos send a couple of dumb Zeno grunts?

Rodrygo: Things would've been so much simpler. I wouldn't have shed a tear over Antonio and Lucas.

Lopera: Open the door!

Rodrygo: Lopera, listen to me!

A third bullet pierces the slim wooden door, grazing across Lopera's clothes and stifling her resistance.

Lopera: —!

Rodrygo: I'd have shot Nydia too, if I were in your father's shoes. I wouldn't have cared who she was or what she wanted.

Rodrygo: If there had been even a chance she might harm my daughter, I wouldn't have let her live.

Rodrygo: Oh, God! My Nita! My little bird, I'm sorry. How could I have let them do that to you?

A rough fist hits the door. Rodrygo slings back his rifle and turns away.

Rodrygo: Fate let you dodge three bullets. You win again, Lopera. May we never meet again.

Lopera cups her hands around a bullet hole in the door and shouts.

Lopera: Where are you taking him?

She presses her ear to the door to hear the footsteps pause for a moment, then slowly return.

Rodrygo: You won't see us again, you hear me! I can't lose him now. He's all I have left.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310210

Alchemy Accident

Lopera: Ugh, darn it! Open this door!

Crack!

Though it's only a thin bit of wood, her small frame can't make it budge an inch. The force propels her back to the center of the room.

Lopera: Traitor! Rodrygo, you lying old jerk! Damn you!

Lopera: You were lying to me from the start!

In a moment of silence, distant gunshots echo through the air.

The gunshots are far from their location. Sandro must have moved further, and Rodrygo must be closing in.

Lopera: Hmm, let me think. There's always a way out. Stay calm, Lopera. I can still find them.

Lopera: A way out, a way out—how do I get out of this?!

Lopera: I'm out of bullets; otherwise, I'd shoot the lock out.

Lopera: Hmm.

Lopera falls back on the rough, damp floor, accidentally tipping over her cauldron. Several gray pellets roll out.

These ones appear to be darker than before. She picks one up and examines it.

Lopera: What's going on? Did those smoke bombs in the cauldron react with something else?

After pondering for a moment, she gives up on trying to understand, tossing the pellets back into the cauldron.

Lopera: Ugh, I've never been able to wrap my head around alchemy.

Lopera: But maybe I can use this thing to make a bomb or something.

Lopera scrapes some gunpowder residue out of her gun barrel and adds it to the cauldron.

Lopera: This should make it more explosive? Let's see, what else can I use?

Lopera: Uh, a rotten banana peel?

Lopera: I guess it could give things a kick of energy, hopefully.

The young alchemist doesn't follow any particular recipe, choosing her materials by intuition alone.

Lopera: This should do! Hopefully, it'll be some kind of bullets or explosives.

Lopera: And it's bound to pack a punch with bombardier beetles in the mix.

She adds a few drops of blood dripping from a wound on her thigh, the doing of a sharp branch during their rainforest trek.

Lopera: Blood, the source of life and strength. That's gotta do the trick.

Lopera: Get boiling, parce!

It shakes like a toad that swallowed a beehive in a single gulp.

The self-heating arcane cauldron transforms her motley materials into a kind of metallic fluid. For a moment, she starts to believe she may actually have the chops to be a professional alchemist.

The fluid begins to broil and smoke, getting darker and hotter by the second.

Lopera: *cough*

Lopera: What's going on? Is this thing about to explode?

It becomes abundantly clear that the cauldron is, indeed, about to explode.

Lopera: Whoa!

Lopera kicks the cauldron toward the door and ducks for cover. There is a dull thud, then—BOOM!

Lopera: —!

Distant gunshots echo again. She remembers her father's words—find Sandro.

???: ...

???: Lo ...

???: ... pera!

???: Lopera!

???: Could it be that ...?

???: No, no, she's alive. She's one tough arcanist.

Bang—

???: You know she's taken a bullet before? Some slum kid that gave her a run for her money once upon a time.

???: She survived then, and she'll survive this time, too.

???: Why did she come to such a place?

???: Looking for Sandro, I guess?

???: What, Sandro? Who's Sandro?

Bang! More gunshots ring out.

???: Forget it; we need to get her out of here.

???: Copy that, Major.

Sandro.

???: Look. Her eyelids twitched!

Bang! More gunshots.

Find Sandro.

Lopera: Sandro?

Lopera: Sandro ... Where is he?

Major Kasyan: My God! You're awake!

Lopera has never seen Major Kasyan like this—drenched in sweat, eyes bloodshot.

Lopera: How did you find this place?

Major Kasyan: You were lucky, Lieutenant. We weren't far away when we heard the explosion.

Lopera: An explosion ... Besides the explosion, did you hear gunshots?

Major Kasyan: There are gunshots everywhere, Lopera. Carlos ...

Lopera: I know, he was killed by the mutineers.

Major Kasyan: Huh. I don't know how you found out, but that's the long and short of it.

Major Kasyan: Traitors didn't manage to take the base. They scattered—now we're on the hunt.

Lopera: I was talking about gunshots in the rainforest. I heard ... I heard gunshots. Constant, distant gunshots.

Major Kasyan: I don't think we heard any gunshots before, just the howling of some wild bears.

Lopera: Tch. Idiota ... Wild bears, here?

Major Kasyan: Are there no bears in Brazil?

Lopera: It must have been the mapinguari.

Major Kasyan: Mapinguari ...?

Lopera regains some energy from her confusing joke. She forces herself back to her feet, taking her blown-up cauldron from the hands of her comrade.

Lopera: Never mind. How many mutineers are there?

Major Kasyan: *cough* At least half of our forces in São Paulo. They did a number on what was left of us too. It will be difficult to take direct action against them until reinforcements arrive.

Major Kasyan: So, for now, we're attempting to keep them disorganized by harassing their positions.

Major Kasyan: One of our prisoners said the rebels and the Apostles Brotherhood are meeting at an estate nearby, but we haven't been able to pinpoint the exact location.

Lopera stays silent, taking several unidentified pills and swallowing them down with water from her canteen.

Major Kasyan: Lieutenant Lopera! I know what you're thinking, but you can't. You may have a concussion!

Lopera: I'll be fine. If there is anything wrong with me, these pills will cure it.

Lopera: I have to find Sandro.

Major Kasyan: Forget Sandro!

Lopera: My orders came directly from Admiral Igor.

Her rescuers exchange glances. The mention of Admiral Igor forces them to set aside their concerns for now.

Major Kasyan: Admiral Igor?

Major Kasyan: Alright, then we find Sandro. But where do we even start?

Lopera: Follow the gunshots, and you'll find him.

Major Kasyan: Gunshots?

Bang—

Major Kasyan: Like ... that?

[English text unavailable]

COL-310211

No Place to Go

Remote Manor

Lopera: What ... What is this place?

Major Kasyan: Some kind of old estate by the look of it.

The soldiers, experienced in jungle warfare, crouch low, hiding their forms in the shade of the tall walled structure.

Lopera: The last shots we heard came from somewhere near here, but there are no signs of any battle.

While there's no sign of battle, a quick investigation soon reveals that within the estate are a large force of Zeno rebels, along with members of the Apostles Brotherhood.

Major Kasyan: If there wasn't a fight, it could mean that Sandro escaped, or he was captured.

Major Kasyan: Then this is the estate the mutineer we interrogated mentioned.

Major Kasyan: There are some oddly dressed people here, besides the rebels and Apostles.

A few strangely dressed individuals sporadically move between the doors and the courtyard, their dark clothes not suited to the Brazilian sun.

Lopera: Manus Vindictae.

Major Kasyan: Look at all these crates. The wood looks bone dry—these must have been brought in recently.

Major Kasyan: This may be their main base of operations. If so, we have an opportunity to deal a lethal blow to them here and now.

Lopera: Be careful. There's someone over there. See that strange, black-haired woman? Those claws of hers don't look like fashion accessories.

Major Kasyan: My God, what is that she's eating? Is that ... human!?

Lopera: Look closer, Major. It's turkey, just an old dry one.

Major Kasyan: That's one big turkey leg.

Major Kasyan: So, what's in God's name is going on here? Rebels, the Brotherhood, clawed cultists?

Lopera: It doesn't matter. Zeno can handle them all the same way.

A small gray pellet bounces in Lopera's hand.

Lopera: Take them out first, ask questions later.

Lopera: Be careful. I have a feeling that the turkey-eating mujer will be a toughie.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310212

???: No! No, no, no!

???: I don't know anything. I don't know!

Lopera: Who are you?

She lowers her eyes, refusing to answer. Lopera doesn't care.

Lopera: And you're with Manus Vindictae?

???: Y-Yes.

Lopera: Then you're going back with the rest of these prisoners.

Her head flutters like a banana leaf in a hurricane.

???: No! I didn't mean that! Please, I haven't any idea who these people are or why they came to São Paulo!

???: I-I only came out here looking for food, and might I say that turkey was utterly revolting.

The bizarre and apparently very hungry woman had been a powerful opponent. Ordinarily, she might be intrigued by her story, true or not, but she had other things on her mind.

Lopera: I need to ask you about a couple of people.

???: O-Of course!

She nods eagerly—desperately.

Lopera: I'm looking for a man named Rodrygo. Middle-aged, tan brown skin, wearing a vest.

She nods frantically, hoping to trade her answers for freedom.

???: I think I saw him, yes! The large man that came out from the forest, he was with someone else; a young man ...

Lopera: A young man?! Could that've been Sandro?

???: I'm afraid I don't know. I didn't know any of them, I swear, I'm not lying!

???: The Brotherhood took the old man and locked him in the basement. The younger man ran away into the forest.

???: I-I could find him for you! I have an excellent sense of smell, if I do say so myself.

Lopera: Forget about it, girlie. You've got bad news written all over you.

???: Please, let me go! I'll be good! I-I'll never see those bloody Manus Vindictae again!

Lopera: You don't really think I'm just going to let you go, right? Sorry, lady, you're going straight to the Zeno lock-up until we know what to do with you.

???: L-Lock-up?!

???: I've told you everything! Please, please, Miss, why can't you just let me go?!

???: I don't want to go to jail! I won't! I won't!

She springs forward, her claws slicing the air, almost scratching the soldiers holding her back.

Zeno Soldier: This wacko cultist's getting out of control!

???: I am not! I'm not in any kind of cult!!

Lopera: Just get her moving. Those arcanum restraints have a time limit.

Two soldiers drag the struggling prisoner away to a particular cell on a particular base.

Rebels, the Apostles Brotherhood, and now Manus Vindictae, the complexity of the situation is now far out of hand.

But she still has one clear and unequivocal purpose—find Rodrygo and, through him, Sandro.

She cannot fail her mission.

Manor Basement

Major Kasyan: This must be the basement.

Rodrygo lies slumped in a corner, unconscious and covered in blood.

Lopera: Yeah, that's him, Rodrygo.

A set of frayed ropes lies around him, along with a sharp, blood-stained stone.

Major Kasyan: He might be bleeding out. I'll check on him.

Major Kasyan steps forward to lift his head, checking for signs of life.

Major Kasyan: —!

Rodrygo suddenly bolts up, seizing the major by the throat, then pulling him close to make him a human shield.

Lopera: Kasyan!

The sharp bloody stone is pressed up to Kasyan's carotid artery—as at the same moment, her revolver is pointed to Rodrygo's forehead.

Major Kasyan: Lope ... He ... doesn't—

Rodrygo: Shut up!

Rodrygo: Drop the gun, or Zeno loses another fine officer, today.

Lopera: Rodrygo, you have no way out!

The hand holding the stone shard trembles, leaving a red gash on Kasyan's neck.

Major Kasyan: Ugh!

Rodrygo: What are you even doing here?!

Lopera: I told you that you'd never keep me locked up.

Lopera: Where is Sandro?

Rodrygo: No! You know I'll never tell! He'll be free of all this soon!

Anxiety and desire churn in Lopera's stomach. Her patience wears thin.

Lopera: One last chance, Rodrygo. Keeping your mouth shut won't help you now. Zeno will find him.

Rodrygo: Sandro isn't involved in any of this. I'm the one at fault here.

Lopera: He isn't involved?

Rodrygo: And Sandro, he's just a kid.

Lopera: I've had it with your lies!

Lopera: You wanna explain why this "innocent kid" had dealings with the Apostles Brotherhood?

Rodrygo: Only because of his idiot father—

Lopera: "Father?" Do you really think you can play the hero here?

Lopera: Did you even once stop to think what would become of Sandro after all this?

Lopera: You're just turning him into another you! A total moron!

Lopera: A turncoat traitor, selling out everyone he knows for a bit of cash!

Lopera: If he grows up to be like you in the end, then he'll be just another conman—always on the run with not a single person that cares whether he lives or dies!

Lopera: Or I can take Sandro back with me. Zeno can turn him around, teach him what honor means.

Rodrygo: Sandro will never go with you! I'll never let Zeno take him!

Rodrygo: An army that brutalizes neighborhoods, then kills its own officers, and you have the gall to tell me about "honor"!?

Lopera: That's never happening again.

Rodrygo: Heh. Little birdie, once there is a first, there will come a second, and a third.

Lopera: You don't know anything, old man.

Father & Rodrygo: No, you're the one who doesn't get it!

Father: I struggled my whole life! Who helped me?! Who gave me a damn thing?!

Father: Nobody!

Father: Everything I have—my family, my property—I earned it, and I'll protect it by any means necessary!

Father: I've never killed anyone innocent; I just did what I had to do. You think every one of them wouldn't have done the same, if they were in my shoes?

Father: I'm sorry about your friend, but it wasn't my fault.

Father: Of course, I care about you. Your friend, her name was Nydia! See, I remember. I'm not as uncaring as you might think.

Lopera: You're lying!

Father: No! Listen!

Father: Don't say it! Don't you open your mouth! Pray I don't hear your voice again today!

Father: Damn you! Just go to your room!

Lopera: I'm never setting foot in that room again!

Lopera: I'm not afraid of you! I'm not afraid of anything. I'll run away. You can't lock me up!

Father: Where will you go?! Take one step outside, and those brutes will tear you apart!

Lopera: Nydia, Laura, and their parents ... They hated you, not me.

Lopera: I've done nothing wrong!

Father: Is that so? What makes you think you deserve to stand here, to live as you do?

Father: I should kick you out, send you back to the banana plantations! Let you experience the disease and death I took you away from! Then you'll see! Then you'll behave!

Lopera: No. Never.

Father: Don't you think you've got their blood on your hands too?!

Lopera: Nothing like that!

Father: You, you have no idea what you're doing!

Lopera: Fine! Then I'll stay ignorant!

Major Kasyan: Lopera!

Lopera: ...

The major grabs Rodrygo's falling body by the arms, gently lowering it to the ground. The shot echoes over and over against the cramped stone chamber, leaving their ears ringing.

Major Kasyan: There's nothing pleasant about a bullet grazing your face.

Major Kasyan: But it's better than a slit throat. I owe you, Lieutenant.

Lopera: Sorry. I'm glad you're okay.

Lopera: Sandro is still out there.

Major Kasyan: Are you insane?

Kasyan shakes Lopera by the shoulders, but quickly stops. The girl looks ready to fall apart.

Major Kasyan: Forget it. I don't care about your orders or mine. Don't go after him. Let it go.

Major Kasyan: I'm taking you back to base to recuperate.

Lopera: But the admiral said ...

A soldier rushes in, interrupting their conversation.

Zeno Soldier: Major, we heard a shot! Is everything okay?

Major Kasyan: I was taken hostage by a prisoner, but Lieutenant Lopera here saved my life.

Zeno Soldier: Your aim is still as flawless as ever, Lieutenant.

Zeno Soldier: Unfortunately, I have something urgent to report.

Zeno Soldier: We found the body of a young man on the perimeter. Seems he died about ten minutes ago.

Zeno Soldier: Gunshot wound, looks to be self-inflicted.

Major Kasyan: My God, this is a dark day.

The Ones on the Bank

COL-310213

The Ones on the Bank

War Cemetery

The misty canopy of the forest blocks out the scorching tropic sun above, leaving the ground perpetually shaded and wet.

Major Kasyan: ...

Major Kasyan gently brushes a freshly engraved tombstone.

Major Kasyan: My dear Antosha, who could have thought this day would come? You always said you'd be the second in our class to become a major.

Lopera: Carlos was a malparido—a swine of the worst kind.

Major Kasyan: He put too much faith in brute force. He used Zeno's bullets and arcanum explosives to get his way, never expecting they could be turned against him.

Major Kasyan: Many of our soldiers here are local recruits. They were caught between their loyalty to their communities and their loyalty to Zeno. Carlos pushed them too far.

Lopera: Did they kill him before he launched the operation?

Major Kasyan: Yes, he never got to give the order. Perhaps that's a good thing. I think if we had gone through with it, all of São Paulo would have turned against Zeno—not just the Apostles Brotherhood.

Lopera: I knew that list was fishy from the start.

Major Kasyan: Choice words, Lieutenant, but I also found concrete evidence in Carlos's files.

Major Kasyan: The informant was a retired veteran from Rio ... Rodrygo.

Lopera: ...!

Lopera: It was him.

Immersed in his story, the major doesn't take notice of Lopera's shock.

Major Kasyan: That's right. I suspect he fabricated the entire list.

Major Kasyan: Like you said, they were all just ordinary people. Some might have had occasional dealings with the gangs, but you know how it is in São Paulo. Such situations are hard for the common folk to avoid.

Major Kasyan: I can only imagine the hell we could have unleashed if we had gone after them.

Major Kasyan: As for asking Zeno to retrieve Sandro from the Brotherhood, I guess that was his condition for acting as an informant.

Lopera: But Zeno would have eventually found out he had given them false information. Why would Rodrygo risk himself like that?

Major Kasyan: I guess he hoped that Sandro would be free and clear before we found out. A man like Rodrygo could get away from this place a thousand different ways.

Major Kasyan: If I were to speculate on his actions from a more negative perspective ...

Kasyan casts an apologetic look Lopera's way.

Major Kasyan: I'd wager he was using you to snatch Sandro from the Brotherhood's grasp, then he'd have shot you in the back of the head on the way back. I guess you were too smart for that, though.

Major Kasyan: Bang ... Then Rodrygo and Sandro would have disappeared forever into the rainforest.

Lopera: ...

The humidity rises to a suffocating level. They don't hear the approaching footsteps.

Admiral Igor: Major Kasyan, Lieutenant.

Lopera: ...!

Major Kasyan: Admiral!

The major raises a perfectly-drilled salute among the tombstones.

Gray eyebrows, gray-blue eyes, and gray-brown tombstones ... Amid these, the girl, who usually burns with a fiery glow, seems almost dimmed.

The old admiral bows his head in mourning. Major Kasyan quietly steps away.

Lopera breaks their silence.

Lopera: Father, it was good of you to come to São Paulo.

She remembers the day—the moment that a fully armed transport helicopter landed with exact precision on the base's helipad.

The lines of loyal Zeno soldiers in formation, saluting up toward the hatch with reverence.

Admiral Igor: I haven't had time to talk with you since coming to São Paulo. Our late General Carlos left me in a mire worse than any Brazilian swamp.

Admiral Igor: We must start over. São Paulo's garrison will be integrated with my own personal guard. This should simplify matters.

Lopera: Hmm.

Lopera doesn't think too much about the details. Her father's military wisdom and character stand unquestionable in her mind.

And she has a long way to go before she can match her father in any of these respects, especially with another mission all but failed.

Lopera: Father.

Admiral Igor: Spit it out.

Lopera: I didn't bring Sandro back. I failed my mission.

Admiral Igor: Sandro.

He speaks the name dryly. It clearly holds no significance to him.

Admiral Igor: You misunderstood your orders.

Lopera: Hm?

Admiral Igor: When you reported to me over—whatever that device was—I ordered you to return to base, not to find Sandro.

Lopera: You didn't want me to find him?

The admiral doesn't reply to her, offering only a rise of his gray brow.

Admiral Igor: You were with Rodrygo then, yes?

Admiral Igor: Allow me to tell you about this man.

Admiral Igor: While deployed in Rio against the cartels, he failed a crucial mission. His identity was exposed. And as a result, his children were kidnapped.

Admiral Igor: They demanded the names of his fellow operatives. He traded them a list for his son, Sandro, but something happened. Their deal fell through, and his daughter was killed.

Lopera: And his fellow operatives ...?

Admiral Igor: A total bloody tragedy, like hell. They were massacred. I'm told there wasn't enough left of them for identification.

Admiral Igor: He deserted his post and quietly made his way to São Paulo. He took the boy with him, but hid him away.

Admiral Igor: It is a pity he died. He might have been a valuable witness.

Lopera: I—

The thick, humid mist fills Lopera's lungs, stifling her words.

The admiral turns away from the rows of tombstones, his demeanor comforting in a way strange and unfamiliar to them both.

Admiral Igor: It was a necessity of war. You had to protect your comrades.

Admiral Igor: I worry your impulsive nature clouds your judgment. Yet on that day, when you had the choice to kill your father, you chose wisely. Self-control, Lopera; this is what I expect from you.

Lopera: I-I'll try to ... control myself.

Her father's hand falls on her shoulder, brushing away her despair like dust.

Admiral Igor: For an arcanist, it is a long and bitter road.

Admiral Igor: But for a soldier, it is nothing. A soldier's career is spent making up for their own failures.

Admiral Igor: Failure is expected, but one's legacy may be decided in only a few key victories.

Admiral Igor: A Manus Vindictae base destroyed, valuable prisoners captured, and supplies seized, each of these victories will aid us in our future operations.

Admiral Igor: I've always been proud of you, Lopera.

Hot tears well up in her eyes, but she holds them back stiffly.

At most, she lets out a sniffle.

Admiral Igor: You are to remain on base for the next few days, rest, and wait for the Timekeeper to arrive in São Paulo. Perhaps you might make some new friends.

Lopera: Uhn ...

Lopera: Father.

Admiral Igor: What is it?

Lopera: You'll set things right in São Paulo, won't you?

Admiral Igor: I won't let those who trampled on our loyalty and honor go unpunished.

Admiral Igor: Zeno is a great and indestructible army. And we are an unbreakable family.

Admiral Igor: I will never betray this army or my children.

The admiral scrapes a leaf off his boot against a dew-coated rock.

Lopera: I trust you, Father.

Lopera looks up, only able to see her father's towering shoulders.